

THE SCALES

Libra



SIZE RANKING 29

BRIGHTEST STAR
Beta (β) 2.6

GENITIVE Librae

ABBREVIATION Lib

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.
May–JuneFULLY VISIBLE
60°N–90°S

This constellation of the zodiac lies just south of the celestial equator between Virgo and Scorpius. Originally, the ancient Greeks visualized the constellation as the claws of the neighboring Scorpius, which is why Libra's brightest stars have names that mean "northern claw" and "southern claw." Libra's present-day identification as Virgo's scales of justice became more common in Roman times.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

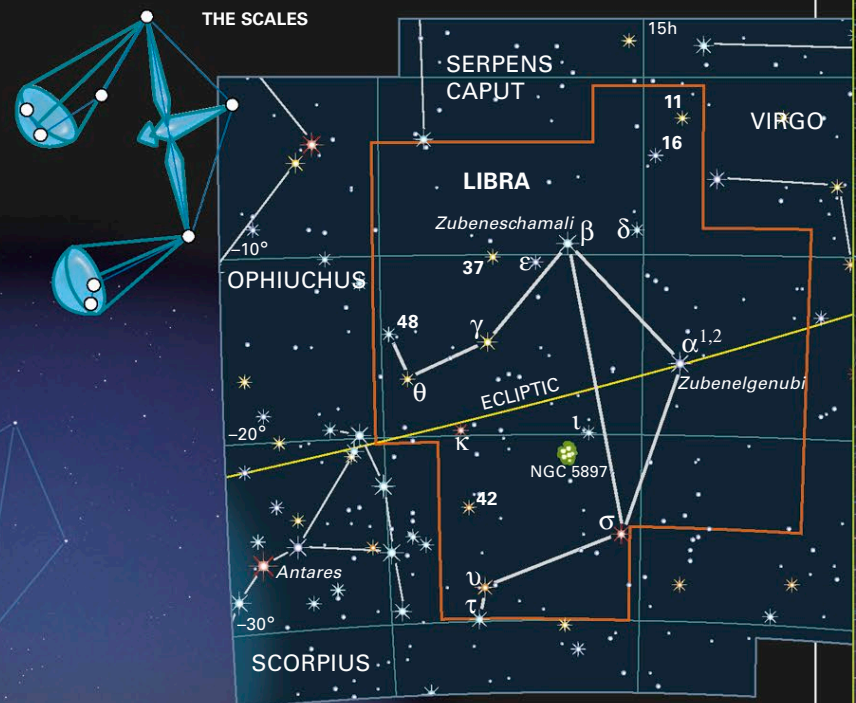
Zubenelgenubi (Arabic for "the southern claw") or Alpha (α) Librae is a wide double star of 3rd and 5th magnitudes and is easily divisible with binoculars or even sharp unaided eyesight. To the north of this pair is the constellation's brightest star,

Zubeneschamali ("the northern claw") or Beta (β) Librae, which shows a greenish tinge when viewed through binoculars or a telescope. This highly unusual coloring is due, presumably, to the chemical composition of Zubeneschamali's outer layers.

In the heart of the constellation lies Iota (ι) Librae, a double with stars of 5th and 6th magnitudes which can be viewed through binoculars. A small telescope will reveal the closer 9th-magnitude companion

of the brighter star. Mu (μ) Librae, with components of 6th and 7th magnitude, is a more difficult pair to separate; a telescope with 3 in (75 mm) aperture is needed.

Delta (δ) Librae is an eclipsing variable. Every 2 days 8 hours, it rises and falls between 5th and 6th magnitudes. This change can be easily followed with binoculars.



LIBRA'S STARS

Now regarded as the scales of justice, the stars of Libra were once visualized as the claws of the adjacent scorpion, Scorpius.

THE NORTHERN CROWN

Corona Borealis



SIZE RANKING 73

BRIGHTEST STAR
Alphecca (α) 2.2GENITIVE
Coronae Borealis

ABBREVIATION CrB

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.
JuneFULLY VISIBLE
90°N–50°S

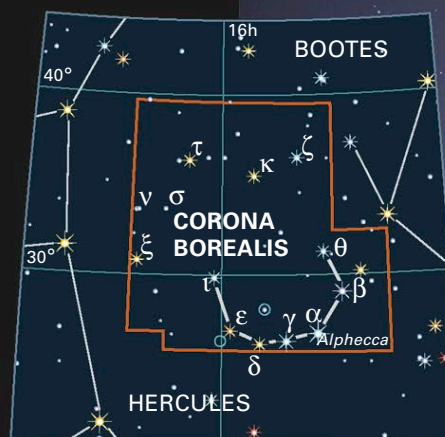
Corona Borealis is a small but distinctive constellation in the northern sky, between Boötes and Hercules, consisting of a horseshoe shape of seven stars. It is one of the original Greek constellations and represents the crown worn by Princess Ariadne (see panel, right).

SPECIFIC FEATURES

The arc of the northern crown contains the remarkable variable star R Coronae Borealis (see p.287), a yellow supergiant normally of 6th magnitude, which shows sudden dips in brightness. These fades, which are due to a build-up of sooty particles in its atmosphere, occur every few years and can last for months.

Corona Borealis has three double stars of note for small-instrument users, although none is particularly bright. Nu (ν) Coronae Borealis is a pair of 5th-magnitude red giants divisible with binoculars. Zeta (ζ) Coronae Borealis is a blue-white pair, with

components of 5th and 6th magnitudes—an attractive sight when seen through a small telescope—while Sigma (σ) Coronae Borealis is a yellow pair with components of 6th and 7th magnitudes, which can also be split with a small telescope.

THE
NORTHERN
CROWN

CROWN OF STARS

Like a celestial tiara, the seven main stars of Corona Borealis form a distinctive arc between Boötes and Hercules.

MYTHS AND STORIES

PRINCESS ARIADNE

Ariadne, daughter of King Minos of Crete, helped Theseus slay the Minotaur, a gruesome creature that was half bull, half human. Theseus sailed off with Ariadne to the island of Naxos, where he then abandoned her. The god Dionysus looked down on the princess and was overcome. At their wedding, Ariadne wore a jewel-studded crown, which Dionysus threw into the sky, where the crown's jewels were changed into stars.

CROWNING GLORY

Dionysus, known as Bacchus by the Romans, holds Ariadne's jeweled crown in this painting by the 17th-century French artist Eustache Le Sueur.

